

Week 2 Enabling Activities

Trade-offs & Constraints

This set covers the full six-activity family for Trade-offs & Constraints, organized as two tracks: 1a–1c build the Benefit → Trade-off → Constraint move in stages; 4a–4c test whether it has proceduralized. These supplement — they do not replace — this week's folder and the ESO/Frames Daily Protocol.

This Week's Frame — Trade-offs & Constraints (W2)

Benefit	Trade-off	Constraint
What does the policy achieve?	What competing good is sacrificed?	Why can't the trade-off simply be avoided?

Key requirement: the constraint step must show why the trade-off is structural — a response that names what's given up without explaining why it can't be preserved alongside the benefit does not meet the standard. Naming a trade-off is not the same as explaining a constraint.

Activity Index

1a. Single-Scenario Depth Ladder · 1b. Sentence-Frame Progression · 1c. 3-Interval Comparison & Paraphrase · 4a. 2-Box Induction · 4b. Silent Protocol & Brief-Back · 4c. Strategic Competence & Fallback

Single-Scenario Depth Ladder — "Scaffold the Scaffold"

Holds one low-stakes scenario constant while building the Benefit → Trade-off → Constraint move in four steps. Use before a student's first W2 attempt, or as remediation if the constraint step isn't yet showing up as structural.

ANCHOR SCENARIO (HELD CONSTANT ACROSS ALL FOUR ITEMS)

A city converts a lane of street parking into a protected bike lane.

1

Surface

"What does converting the parking lane to a bike lane achieve?"

Name one benefit only.

2

Surface → Deep

"What is given up to get that benefit?"

Add the Trade-off box. Just name what's sacrificed — don't explain why yet.

3

Deep

"The city gains safer cycling routes. Local businesses lose customer parking, and ____."

Complete the Constraint — why the trade-off can't just be undone (the street width is fixed).

4

Transfer

"Should cities convert more downtown streets to bike lanes?"

Full response: benefit + trade-off + constraint, no connector given.

Instructor note: 5–10 minute warm-up. A student who completes Item 4 without hesitation is ready for the Week 2 folder.

Causal Subordination → Concessive Subordination → Appositive

Builds subordinate-clause complexity in three tiers using connectors that read as ILR 2+/3, not just connectors that are technically subordinating. Coordinating conjunctions (FANBOYS) are excluded — and so are 'because' and 'so': both are grammatically fine, but they're exactly the safe, overused connectors that inflate a proficiency ceiling. T1 uses higher-register causal subordinators with more precision.

SCENARIO

A city converts a lane of street parking into a protected bike lane.

T1

Causal subordination — given that / on the grounds that / considering that

Complete each sentence, naming one benefit.

- "Cyclists support the new bike lane given that ____."
- "The city council is willing to approve the conversion on the grounds that ____."
- "Nearby businesses remain open to the idea considering that ____."

T2

Concessive subordination — although / while / even though

Hold the benefit and the trade-off in tension inside one sentence.

- "While cyclists gain a safer route, local drivers ____."
- "Although the bike lane reduces accidents, nearby shop owners ____."
- "Even though the city gains a greener image, businesses along the route ____."

T3

Appositives — "Fact, ____, Fact"

Embed a stakeholder's benefit-or-cost identity as a defining phrase inside the sentence.

MODEL

"Cyclists, the primary beneficiaries of the new protected lane, report feeling safer commuting, while local shop owners, facing a steep drop in curbside customers, argue the trade-off wasn't fairly weighed."

Instructor note: 'because' and 'so' aren't FANBOYS, but they're the safe, overused connectors that flag a proficiency ceiling. T1 swaps them for 'given that' / 'on the grounds that' / 'considering that' — same causal entry point, higher register from the first sentence. Move to T2 only once T1 is fluent. T3 stretch — optional for students still consolidating the core requirement.

Comparison & Paraphrase Prompts

Connects trade-off vocabulary to comparative sentence structures, moving from a simple one-line comparison to a claim that explicitly names the trade-off as structural.

COMPARISON PAIR

How the bike lane's benefit to cyclists compares with its cost to local businesses.

Target Lexicon — must appear at least once

trade-off

inherent

structural

at the
expense
of

on the
whole

1

Surface

"In one sentence, compare the benefit cyclists get from the new lane with the cost local businesses bear."

2

Deep

"Using structural, explain whether the cost to businesses is incidental or built into the design of the bike lane itself."

3

Transfer

"Write one complex sentence connecting the benefit to cyclists and the cost to businesses, using inherent or at the expense of."

Instructor note: score for lexicon use and whether the response correctly identifies the trade-off as structural — not for stance on whether the bike lane is worth it.

Visual Synthesis

Forces students to infer what makes a trade-off complete versus incomplete from grouped, unlabeled examples — no rule is stated up front.

Box A

- The company saved \$2M a year by switching to remote work.
- The city cut traffic accidents by installing more streetlights.
- The school raised test scores by extending the school day.

Box B

- The company saved \$2M a year by switching to remote work, but lost the spontaneous collaboration that used to happen in the office.
- The city cut traffic accidents by installing more streetlights, but raised its annual energy costs by 15%.
- The school raised test scores by extending the school day, but cut into students' time for after-school jobs and family responsibilities.

TASK

What is missing from the statements in Box A that Box B includes? Why is a Box B–style statement a stronger analytical claim? Answer using a concessive subordinating conjunction — although, while, or even though.

Instructor note: don't pre-explain the boxes. Box A statements aren't wrong, they're incomplete for this week's purposes. Let the student name what's missing before you confirm it.

Silent Modeling & Pre-Attempt Brief-Back

Separates rule comprehension from production. Students extract the frame's structure from a marked-but-unexplained model, then must plan out loud before they're allowed to attempt their own response.

PHASE 1 — SILENT MODELING

Read the response below. Three elements are marked [A], [B], [C]. No explanation is given — identify what each represents before moving to Phase 2.

[A] The city gains safer cycling routes and reduced traffic emissions along the corridor — a direct benefit for commuters who switch from driving to biking. **[B]** But that same redesign removes forty on-street parking spaces that local shop owners relied on for customer turnover. **[C]** Because the street's width is fixed, there's no way to add the bike lane without removing an equivalent amount of parking somewhere on that block — the trade-off isn't a side effect of poor planning, it's the only way the two uses can physically coexist on the same strip of pavement.

Key (reveal only after Phase 2). In the digital version, each move is color-highlighted. In print, use letter markers above.



[A] = Benefit



[B] =
Trade-off



[C] =
Constraint

PHASE 2 — VERBAL BRIEF-BACK ("PLAN BEFORE YOU PRODUCE")

Before attempting your own response to the prompt below, say out loud — or write in one sentence — your plan for each of the frame's three moves. Do not begin your full response until you've stated your plan.

PROMPT FOR PHASE 2 ATTEMPT

"Should cities make new bike lanes permanent after a trial period, or restore the parking once testing ends?"

Instructor note: the brief-back is a planning checkpoint, not a rehearsal — keep it to one sentence. This models a legitimate strategy: a brief pause to organize before speaking.

Fallback Scaffolding

Tests whether the frame's core move survives without its own vocabulary — the ILR 3 skill of knowing what to do when the exact word isn't available.

CONSTRAINT

Answer the prompt below without using the words benefit, trade-off, or constraint.

PROMPT

"Should cities convert more downtown streets to bike lanes?"

Fallback Strategies to Practice

a

Circumlocution

Instead of "trade-off," try "what has to give" or "the thing you lose to get this."

b

Term substitution

Instead of "benefit" / "constraint," try "what's gained" / "the reason it can't be avoided."

c

Self-correction

"What I mean is..." / "Let me put that another way..."

d

Hedging

"It seems to come with a cost..." / "This tends to require giving something up..."

Instructor note: use after a student is reliably using the frame vocabulary — this is a stress test, not a first attempt.